



with a clearance of 5.35m in Kochi.

The fact that he made his clearance in his first attempt at that height, and by several inches, suggests that there are more records on the horizon. "I think I could have jumped 5.45m or even 5.50 without doing anything different," he told *Sportstar* after the competition.

However, unexpected rain shortly after his 5.35m clearance meant Dev chose not to risk slipping while attempting a higher jump. As a result, he missed the opportunity to qualify for the Asian Championships, with the AFI holding firm on the 5.51m qualification standard. Though he won't compete again until the National Inter-State Championships in August, Dev's steady progress suggests another record could well be on the horizon.

While Dev will have to wait to get a chance to show his ability, a fair number of athletes will get their chance very soon at the Asian Championships. Twinkle Chaudhary (2:00.71) clocked the fourth-fastest time by an Indian in the 800m, while 22-year-old Pooja from Haryana wasn't far behind with an impressive

time of 2:02.89.

Tejaswin Shankar (7603) came within 63 points of his own national record of 7666 in the men's decathlon, set at the Asian Games in Hangzhou. It's a number Tejaswin says he could have crossed by 100 points if conditions had been more favourable — and he will get that chance in the far cooler climes of Gumi, South Korea, in a few weeks.

For some others, the Fed Cup was an important return to form. Perhaps no athlete would feel this as strongly as Shaili Singh. The 21-year-old was seen as the heir apparent to her coach, World bronze medallist Anju Bobby George, after making the second-best ever jump by an Indian (6.76m) in 2023.

Since then, though, Shaili has struggled, as injuries — first to her shoulder at the Asian Games and then subsequently to her take-off leg — took their toll. Despite her best efforts, she failed to qualify for the Paris Olympics.

2025, though, is a new start. Shaili seems to have found her feet with a jump of 6.64m in the women's long jump. The jump was a new meet

On the mark: Shaili Singh's 6.64m long jump was a new meet record.

THULASI KAKKAT

record, erasing the 23-year-old mark of 6.59m set by Anju.

While Shaili appears to be on the right track, she will have company in Gumi. Asian Games silver medallist Ancy Sojan seemed to be struggling for much of the competition before clearing 6.46m in her penultimate jump. She then concluded with a monstrous jump that seemed well over the 6.70m mark — but for the unfortunate blemish of starting a millimetre beyond the take-off board. She'll get her chance soon enough — as will some of India's best athletes.

They might have started off impressively, but they know that the real test of the season begins now. That's certainly what Chithravel believes.

"Now the real challenge starts. It's not just important to have one or two big performances. We have to show that we can consistently stay at this level," he says.